

injuries, and enduring structural and tactical flaws reduced a campaign that began with much promise to a tame whimper.

The Indian T20 side of 2026 is, one would expect, a wiser setup. It has gone through the highs of an ODI World Cup triumph last year, which, too, didn't come easily, courtesy a gruelling soul-searching exercise where three defeats to the three biggest sides nearly threatened to push India out of contention in a home World Cup, before a remarkable resurgence and wave of belief carried it to the podium.

It is also an outfit that is reaping the benefits of four editions of the Women's Premier League, both in talent acquisition and exposure. N. Shree Charani, Kranti Gaud and Nandni Sharma are direct WPL-highlighted selections in the last two years.

Bharti Fulmali finds herself back in the Indian setup after seven years, and Radha Yadav and Arundhati Reddy have wriggled their way into national reckoning thanks to commendable WPL stints alongside their domestic grind.

### Old problems, new year

And yet, the whole is not exactly greater than the sum of its parts. The bowling reinforcements hogged the limelight, particularly with India's pace all-rounder pool hampered by injuries.

Renuka Singh didn't feature in India's preparatory series against England, either. This conversation, though, has allowed mediocre batting performances — and the discussions around them — to run on autopilot.

The Amol Muzumdar-led think tank is yet to find its perfect middle-order combination. Ahead of the 2024 edition, India's musical chairs around the No. 3 position invited several auditionees.

Jemimah Rodrigues, Dayalan Hemalatha, Sajeevan Sajana, skipper Harmanpreet Kaur herself, and even Richa Ghosh were tried out there.

Records and, perhaps more



importantly, logic would suggest that slot go to Jemimah; her ability to grind out runs and keep the scoreboard ticking is more valuable in the face of a middle-overs crawl than at the end, when the ask is a big finish.

It is a slot she thrives in, as seen in most of 2025, although in the longer white-ball format. However, her versatility can extend to No. 4 as well, as evidenced in India's 1-2 series loss to England, where, in the first T20I she scored a sublime 69 off 40 balls.

Yastika Bhatia's return was encouraging. She scored briskly alongside Jemimah, but the series exposed old patterns — sluggish

**On the move:** Jemimah Rodrigues' ability to grind out runs and keep the scoreboard ticking makes her an apt choice for the No. 3 slot.

running between the wickets, a tendency to slow down midway through an innings and struggle to recover. She was even retired out in the second T20I.

Harmanpreet locking the No. 4 slot for herself opens up a few issues for India. Allowing Yastika to come in ahead of her and slotting herself in more as a power-hitter might be what India could use in testing English conditions. India did that in the